MODI'S BIG ELECTORAL HURDLES

FOR THE PRIME MINISTER AND THE BJP, THE NINE STATE ELECTIONS WILL BE THE SEMIFINALS FOR THE 2024 GENERAL ELECTION; FOR THE CONGRESS, ITS LAST CHANCE TO REVIVE

By **RAJ CHENGAPPA**

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Narendra Modi created history of sorts when he led the Bharatiya Janata Party to back-to-back victories in the 2014 and 2019 general elections, equalling a feat that was last achieved more than 50 years ago, by Indira Gandhi in 1971. However, when it came to assembly elections, doubts were raised about the prime minister's pulling power. In the 23 state polls held between 2018 and 2021, the BJP's only outright wins came in the northeastern states of Tripura and Arunachal Pradesh. The rest of its victories, be it in Maharashtra, Bihar, three northeastern states or in Puducherry, came in alliance with other parties. Only in 2022, when the BJP registered three convincing wins in Uttar Pradesh, Gujarat and Uttarakhand, did the Modi magic appear in full flow. While that is good news for the BJP, the narrow defeat in Himachal Pradesh due to internal schisms served as a sobering reminder of the threat within.

In 2023, with nine states slated to go for elections, the stakes are high not just for the BJP but also for the Congress and other Opposition parties. For Modi and the BJP, big wins in these states will place them in pole position to win the 2024 general election. While Modi's popularity remains high, a sputtering economy, inflation and unemployment could adversely impact the BJP's electoral fortunes. Modi's advantage is that having delivered on the Hindutva front, whether it's the construction of the Ram Temple in Ayodhya or the abrogation of Article 370 in Kashmir, he can concentrate on key developmental issues that can help him consolidate his party's hold over national affairs. India's helmsmanship of the G20 this year will be an additional feather in his cap. Meanwhile, the Opposition space is no longer static. For Rahul Gandhi and the Congress, this cluster of elections could be their last big chance for a major revival after the party's morale-boosting win in Himachal. It will also be a verdict on

WHILE MODI RETAINS HIS POPULARITY, A **SPUTTERING ECONOMY, INFLATION AND UNEMPLOYMENT** MAY MAR BJP FORTUNES